

purchase or ways to profile them. The app has seen half-a-million downloads so far.

But just how serious is the Chauhan family about Bisleri International? Last November, Chairman Ramesh Chauhan went on the record stating that discussions for a sale were being held with Tata Consumer Products in a deal pegged at over ₹6,000 crore. It would help the buyer, a small player in the water business, strengthen its presence. By March, the deal was reported to have been called off.

Jayanti Chauhan, without getting into specifics, says the company is in a sweet spot. “We want to create the most unique product portfolio and are very serious about the business. Bisleri comes with a lot of trust and quality. Our focus is to grow the business, be innovative and [we] are not even thinking of a sale,” she says categorically.



ANAND KUMAR JAISWAL
PROFESSOR OF
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AHMEDABAD

“Xerox is the best example [of being generic to a category] and something similar has taken place with Bisleri, India’s first packaged water brand”

THE WAY FORWARD

In a business as dynamic as this, the search for new markets is a never-ending exercise. For Bisleri, the next stop will be the overseas markets and Chauhan has set her eyes first on the UAE. “The plan is to be there by the end of the year,” she says.

The large Indian diaspora is obviously one reason. “It is really an extension of India with a sizeable expat population,” she points out. Besides, there is almost no piped water in the UAE and the packaged version dominates. The key markets in the UAE—Dubai, Sharjah and Abu Dhabi, among others—have three-four large brands like Masafi and Mai Dubai. “Consumers look for quality and trust,” says Angelo. The plan is to first go with Bisleri through contract manufacturing for now, before looking at the possibility of taking other brands from the portfolio. “We would obviously like to be present in more markets outside India. That is apart from having more manufacturing units in India,” adds Chauhan.

As for strategy, Chauhan says that in terms of profitability and volumes, the business must double in four-five years. “Nothing would make me happier than Vedica getting to a certain level apart from soft drinks too taking off,” she says. The company is looking for a compound annual growth rate of 25 per cent, which Angelo thinks is tough but eminently achievable.

For Chauhan, the Bisleri journey has barely begun. It is one that she initially saw from close quarters and is now in the thick of. She feels this is the brand’s big moment with an unlimited potential to grow. The stage is well and truly set for the next round. **BT**

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80% of the world's disease cases are traceable to unclean water. —WHO Report

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